

All India Survey on Higher Education Reports for 2022-23 and 2023-24



For Prelims: All India Survey on Higher Education , Gross Enrolment Ratio , Anusandhan National Research Foundation , National Education Policy (NEP) 2020

For Mains: Higher Education Reforms in India, Skill Mismatch and India's Demographic Dividend, Concerns Regarding Student Mental Health and Exam-Centric Education System

Source: PIB

Why in News?

The **Union Ministry of Education** has released the **All India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE) Reports for 2022-23 and 2023-24** , highlighting significant growth in higher education enrolment, **Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER)**, female participation, social inclusion, and STEM education in India.

Summary

- **AISHE Reports 2022-24 highlight significant expansion and inclusion in India's higher education sector** , with rising enrolment, GER, female participation, social-group representation, and STEM education.
- **Despite quantitative progress, structural challenges persist** , including graduate unemployment, skill gaps, faculty shortages, low R&D investment, regional and digital divides, weak institutional autonomy, and uneven quality of education.

What are the Key Highlights of AISHE 2022-23 & 2023-24?

- **Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER):** GER, calculated as the ratio of student enrolment to total population in the age group of 18-23 years based on 2011 population projection.

- GER increased from **23.7 in 2014-15 to 30 in 2023-24** . Female GER rose from **22.9 to 31.2** , while GER for **Scheduled Caste (SC) students increased from 18.9 to 27.8** and for **Scheduled Tribe (ST) students from 13.5 to 22.8** during the same period.
- **Gender Parity Index (GPI):** GPI, the ratio of female GER to male GER, stood at **1.08 in 2023-24** and has remained above 1 for **seven consecutive years** , indicating consistently higher female participation in higher education.
- **Higher Education Enrolment:** Total enrolment increased by **31.5%** , from **3.42 crore in 2014-15 to 4.50 crore in 2023-24** .
 - Female enrolment grew faster by **42.2%** , reaching **2.24 crore** .
- **Enrolment of Social Groups:** Since 2014-15, enrolment increased by **51.4% among SC students, 75.7% among ST students and 60.2% among OBC students** , reaching **69.72 lakh, 28.83 lakh and 1.80 crore** , respectively, in 2023-24.
- **STEM Enrolment:** STEM enrolment increased from **91.5 lakh in 2014-15 to 1.02 crore in 2023-24** , while the share of female students in STEM rose from **38.4% to 44%** , indicating greater gender inclusion.
- **Faculty Strength:** The total number of faculty members reached **17.32 lakh in 2023-24** , comprising **55.1% males and 44.9% females** . Female faculty strength increased from **5.69 lakh in 2014-15 to 7.78 lakh in 2023-24** .

All India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE)

- **Background:** Initiated in 2010-11, AISHE is an annual, comprehensive, and voluntary survey conducted by the Ministry of Education.
- **Mandate:** It acts as the primary source of official statistics on India's higher education sector, aiding in policy formulation and resource allocation.
- **Data Collection:** It tracks indicators like student enrolment, faculty data, infrastructure, and examination outcomes via a web-based **Data Capture Format (DCF)** .
- **Limitations of AISHE Data:** Participation is voluntary, and data is self-reported by **Higher Education Institutions (HEIs)** . Although the Ministry conducts inbuilt validations, data quality relies heavily on the reporting institutions, and large-scale survey limitations may marginally affect the findings.

What are the Persistent Challenges in the Higher Education Sector?

- **The Employability & Unemployment Crisis:** The **State of Working India 2026** report highlights a severe **youth employment crisis** , with unemployment at nearly **40% among graduates under 25 and around 20% among those aged 25-29** .
 - Compounding this, **India Skills Report 2025** , notes that the national employability rate stands at just **54.81%** , highlighting a persistent mismatch between the skills possessed by the workforce and those demanded by the labour market.
- **Scale vs. Quality Trade-off:** While India leads with the highest volume of ranked institutions at 128 universities in the **Times Higher Education (THE) Asia University Rankings 2026** , **none cracked**

the top 40.

- Furthermore, many **premier IITs boycott these rankings** citing opaque evaluation parameters.
- **Rural-Urban Divide:** The **Economic Survey 2025-26** flags acute geographic barriers; urban areas hold **38.1% of secondary schools**, leaving rural areas with **higher dropout rates and forcing rural youth into lower-tier local colleges**.
- **Severe Faculty Shortages:** A **March 2025 Parliamentary Standing Committee report** exposed that **28% of teaching and 48% of non-teaching posts in central universities remain vacant**.
 - The reliance on ad-hoc staff dilutes teaching quality and exacerbates academic "brain drain."
- **Student Mental Health Epidemic:** Hyper-competitive exams like **NEET and JEE** have triggered severe stress.
 - Studies show **70% of students face anxiety**, and **National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB)** continuously flags student suicides as a critical concern requiring a shift away from rote-learning.
- **Stagnant R&D Investment:** India's **Gross Expenditure on Research and Development (GERD) remains stagnant at 0.6% to 0.7% of GDP**, falling well below the global average.
 - Central funding via **PM-USA and the Anusandhan National Research Foundation** is tied to mandatory compliance with Union reform agendas, while consolidating grant-giving powers within the Central Ministry strips states of the autonomy to fund local research priorities.
- **Unregulated Privatization & Debt Traps:** **Private universities account for over 35% of all Higher Education Institutions (HEIs)** as of 2024, but very few hold an **"A" grade by NAAC**.
 - Amidst quality concerns, the **Supreme Court ordered a nationwide audit in November 2025**.
- **Fiscal Starvation of State Universities:** While central institutes (IITs, IIMs) receive heavy funding, **State Public Universities which handle over 85% of total student enrollment are functionally bankrupt** and plagued by infrastructural deficits.
- **Divorce of Research and Teaching:** India's research ecosystem isolates cutting-edge work in autonomous laboratories (**CSIR, ICAR, DRDO**), leaving university campuses intellectually hollowed out compared to globally integrated models.
- **Bureaucratization & Digital Divide:** Heavy regulation by bodies like the **UGC and AICTE** stifles institutional autonomy, hindering the goals of the **National Education Policy (NEP) 2020**. Meanwhile, **32.5% of rural students lack broadband access**, creating a new "educational apartheid."
- **Education Debt Trap:** Over 75% of Higher Education Institutions (HEIs) in India are privately managed. The unregulated proliferation of substandard, self-financed engineering and management colleges has commodified education.
 - Students from middle and lower-income families take on massive educational loans to afford these "degree mills," leading to a **rising Non-Performing Asset (NPA) crisis in retail education loans** as graduates fail to secure well-paying jobs.

What Measures are Needed to Strengthen India's Higher Education System?

- **Chasing the NEP Target:** The **National Education Policy (NEP) 2020** envisions achieving a **50% Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER) by 2035**, which necessitates **ramping up public investment in education towards the target of 6% of GDP** to build robust institutional capacity.
- **Promoting Multidisciplinary Learning:** Breaking strict silos between STEM and Humanities through full operationalization of the **Academic Bank of Credits (ABC)** and flexible **multiple entry-exit options** is vital for holistic education.

- **Venture-Based Research & Deep-Tech Innovation:** Transitioning from passive "grant-based" models to a **"venture-based" research funding model** where the **Anusandhan National Research Foundation (ANRF)** acts as a strategic equity partner will catalyze university-led deep-tech startups and democratize funding for tier-2/tier-3 Higher Education Institutions (HEIs).
- **Performance-Linked Regulatory Autonomy:** The current "one-size-fits-all" regulatory oversight by bodies like UGC and AICTE must be replaced with a **tiered autonomy framework linked directly to NAAC accreditation and NIRF rankings**, allowing top-performing colleges administrative and financial freedom to design hyper-localized curricula.
- **Industry-Academia Co-Governance:** Incorporating a **fixed percentage of active industry practitioners and global entrepreneurs onto university Governing Boards** ensures that curricula remain highly market-responsive, introducing modular "micro-credentials" and "stackable degrees."
- **National Faculty Mobility & Reversing Brain Drain:** Addressing acute shortages by creating a **National Faculty Exchange (NFE) program** allows corporate experts and global NRIs to take academic sabbaticals, injecting practical insights into university classrooms.
- **Deploying "AI-First" Personalized Infrastructure:** Utilizing Large Language Models (LLMs) to **translate global research into 22 Indian languages via the SWAYAM and DIKSHA platforms** will bridge the "last-mile" digital divide for rural and vernacular-medium learners.
- **Trans-Disciplinary Design Thinking:** Restructuring foundational curricula to include mandatory courses in **"Design Thinking" and "Computational Logic"** across all academic streams will generate agile, "T-shaped" professionals capable of managing multi-sectoral societal issues.

Conclusion

India can no longer afford to let its demographic dividend become a historic **dropout**; the nation must rewrite its structural syllabus to **major** in innovation rather than **minor** in rote compliance. By **graduating** from rigid regulatory silos and **enrolling** in an agile, venture-driven ecosystem, we can finally bridge the gap between rote learning and real earning. Ultimately, passing this **test** of systemic reform is the only true **prerequisite** for India to earn its **degree** as a global knowledge superpower.

Drishti Mains Question:

India's demographic dividend could become a demographic liability unless higher education institutions address the employability crisis. Comment.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the All India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE)?

AISHE is an **annual, voluntary survey conducted by the Ministry of Education since 2010-11** to collect official data on enrolment, faculty, infrastructure, institutions, and examination outcomes in higher education.

2. What are the major findings of the AISHE Reports 2022-24?

India's **GER reached 30** , total enrolment increased to **4.50 crore** , female GER rose to **31.2** , GPI stood at **1.08** , and STEM enrolment reached **1.02 crore** in 2023-24.

3. What is the higher education target under the National Education Policy 2020?

NEP 2020 aims to increase the Gross Enrolment Ratio in higher education to 50% by 2035 , alongside multidisciplinary education, institutional autonomy, flexibility, and improved research capacity.

4. What are the major challenges facing India's higher education system?

Major challenges include **graduate unemployment, skill mismatch, faculty shortages, low R&D expenditure, rural-urban and digital divides, weak state universities, commercialisation, and limited institutional autonomy** .

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Q. Which of the following provisions of the Constitution does India have a bearing on Education? (2012)

1. Directive Principles of State Policy
2. Rural and Urban Local Bodies
3. Fifth Schedule
4. Sixth Schedule
5. Seventh Schedule

Select the correct answer using the codes given below:

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 3, 4 and 5 only
- (c) 1, 2 and 5 only
- (d) 1, 2, 3, 4 and 5

Ans- (d)

Mains

Q. National Education Policy 2020 is in conformity with the Sustainable Development Goal-4 (2030). It intends to restructure and reorient the education system in India. Critically examine the statement. (2020)

Q. How have digital initiatives in India contributed to the functioning of the education system in the country? Elaborate on your answer. (2020)

Geneva Conventions and War Crimes



Source: TH

Why in News?

The **Geneva Conventions of 1949** have come into sharp focus in the context of the “**Hummus Trail**” **controversy in India** , following a legal petition by the Hind Rajab Foundation (HRF) seeking the arrest of an Israeli soldier vacationing in Himachal Pradesh over alleged **war crimes in Gaza**.

- This development has triggered a complex debate intersecting international humanitarian law, India's domestic legal obligations, and sovereign administrative powers.

What is the Hummus Trail?

- **Hummus Trail:** It is a colloquial term for a network of Indian destinations frequently visited by **young Israeli travellers, particularly veterans completing mandatory military service** .
 - The **Hummus Trail** , named after the **Hippie or Hashish Trail of the 1970s-80s** , refers to a popular travel route associated with Israeli backpackers and, historically, recreational drug culture.
 - Major destinations include **Kasol, Dharamkot, Rishikesh, Pushkar, Goa, Hampi, Gokarna, Kodaikanal and the Andaman and Nicobar Islands** .
- **Tiul Gadol:** Around **80,000 Israeli tourists reportedly visit India annually** , including young veterans undertaking the **Tiul Gadol or ‘Big Trip’** , a post-military-service journey that may last between **six months and one year** and is often financed through post-service benefits.
 - In 2026, Israel allocated 4 million NIS to boost tourism cooperation and bilateral tourist flows with India.



What is India's Legal Framework for Addressing Breaches of the Geneva Conventions?

- **Geneva Conventions:** The **Four Geneva Conventions of 1949** and their Additional Protocols form the core of International Humanitarian Law (IHL) and protect people affected by armed conflicts.
 - The **First Convention** protects wounded and sick soldiers on land, the **Second protects** wounded, sick and shipwrecked military personnel at sea, and the **Third protects** prisoners of war.
 - **Fourth Geneva Convention (1949)** protects civilians during armed conflicts and treats certain serious violations, including **wilful killing, torture and extensive destruction of property not justified by military necessity**, as **grave breaches**.
 - The **universal jurisdiction clauses of the 1949 Geneva Conventions** require signatory states to search for, prosecute, or extradite individuals suspected of "grave breaches" (war crimes), regardless of the perpetrator's or victim's nationality.
- **India's Domestic Legal Framework:** While India does not possess a standalone domestic penal code for war crimes, it passed the **Geneva Conventions Act, 1960**, which explicitly criminalizes acts defined as '**grave breaches**' under the four international Geneva Conventions.
 - Under the **Geneva Conventions Act, 1960**, India holds the legal mandate to **arrest and prosecute any individual, irrespective of nationality**, if found within Indian territory and accused of a grave breach, **regardless of the geographical location** where the alleged crime occurred.
- **Administrative Remedies:** In scenarios where formal criminal prosecution or judicial arrest is not initiated, the **Ministry of Home Affairs** and immigration authorities retain the sovereign power to **facilitate the immediate deportation** of the accused foreign national.
- **Global Precedents on Universal Jurisdiction:** Advocacy groups like the HRF have successfully triggered **universal jurisdiction clauses of Geneva Convention in domestic courts across Chile, Brazil, and Canada**, increasing diplomatic pressure on host nations to deny impunity routes.
- **Key Issue for India:** The Hummus Trail situation highlights the diplomatic challenge of balancing **India's growing strategic partnership with Israel** with its **obligations under international law**, particularly amid **South Africa's genocide case against Israel before the International Court of Justice (ICJ)**.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What are the Geneva Conventions of 1949?

The **Four Geneva Conventions of 1949** form the core of **International Humanitarian Law (IHL)** and protect wounded soldiers, shipwrecked military personnel, prisoners of war and civilians during armed conflicts.

2. What are 'grave breaches' under the Geneva Conventions?

Grave breaches are serious violations of the Geneva Conventions, including **wilful killing, torture, inhuman treatment and extensive destruction of property not justified by military necessity**.

3. What is the Geneva Conventions Act, 1960?

The **Geneva Conventions Act, 1960** gives effect to the Geneva Conventions in India and provides for the punishment of persons committing grave breaches under specified circumstances.

4. What is the Hummus Trail?

The **Hummus Trail** is a colloquial term for a network of Indian destinations popular among young Israeli travellers, particularly veterans undertaking the **Tiul Gadol (Big Trip)** after completing mandatory military service.

[Watch Video on YouTube: [▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/8pGZqddRmAw](https://www.youtube.com/embed/8pGZqddRmAw)]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs) *Prelims*

Q. Which of the following international conventions have not been ratified by India ? (2026)

1. Employment Policy Convention
2. Abolition of Forced Labour Convention
3. International Convention on the Protection of the Rights of All Migrant Workers and Members of Their Families
4. Geneva Convention Relative to the Protection of Civilian Persons in Time of War
5. Convention on Reduction of Statelessness

Select the answer using the code given below :

- (a) 2 and 4
- (b) 1 and 2
- (c) 3 and 4 only
- (d) 3, 4 and 5

Ans: d

Agreement on Sardar Sarovar Project Financial Disputes



Source: TH

In a landmark development for **cooperative federalism** , the states of **Maharashtra, Gujarat, Rajasthan, and Madhya Pradesh** have signed a **one-time settlement agreement** to resolve decades-old financial disputes concerning the cost-sharing and pending dues of the **Sardar Sarovar Project (SSP)** .

- **Scope of Disputes:** The agreement resolves complex financial conflicts including **cost-sharing of the Sardar Sarovar and Indira Sagar projects** , **Resettlement and Rehabilitation (R&R)** expenditures for displaced communities, and the massive interest burden on construction-phase borrowings.
 - In a move to facilitate closure, **Gujarat agreed to increase its share of project costs to 75%** (up from 50%), effectively reducing the financial burden on Madhya Pradesh.
- **Sardar Sarovar Project (SSP):** It is a **terminal gravity dam** built on the **Narmada River** near Navagam, Gujarat.
 - Located near the **Statue of Unity** , the **Sardar Sarovar Dam** is the largest major dam planned on the Narmada and one of the world's largest concrete gravity dams by volume of concrete used.
 - The idea of harnessing the **Narmada River** was envisioned by **Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel in 1946** , and the project gained momentum when **Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru laid the foundation stone in 1961** .
 - The SSP is one of the largest water resource projects in India, covering four major states Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, Gujarat, and Rajasthan.
 - It provides critical irrigation, drinking water, and hydropower. The project has transformed arid and drought-prone regions, particularly in Rajasthan and Gujarat, significantly enhancing agricultural productivity and skyrocketing land values.
- **Narmada Water Disputes Tribunal (NWDT):** The NWDT, constituted in 1969 under the **Inter-State River Water Disputes Act, 1956**, delivered its final award in 1979, determining the water and power-sharing arrangements among the four beneficiary States.
 - While these allocations were largely settled, disputes over land compensation, rehabilitation costs, and shared infrastructure expenses persisted for decades.
- **Narmada River:** It is the **largest river of Central India and Gujarat** , originates from the **Amarkantak Plateau in Madhya Pradesh** and flows into the Arabian Sea through the Gulf of Khambhat (Cambay) in Gujarat.
 - Spanning **1,312 km across Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, and Gujarat** , it drains a vast basin of about **98,800 sq. km** , making it one of India's most important west-flowing rivers.



[Read more: Narmada River](#)

Mission Drishti Loses Communication After Solar Storm



Source: TH

Mission Drishti, the **world’s first OptoSAR satellite** lost communication after developing an anomaly caused by a **geomagnetic solar storm** . Preliminary analysis indicates that radiation from the storm affected a critical onboard system during the final stage of the Launch and Early Orbit Phase.

Mission Drishti

- **Opto-SAR Technology:** Drishti was the world’s first satellite designed to capture optical multi-spectral and **Synthetic Aperture Radar (SAR)** images of the same location simultaneously.
- **Solving the Tropical Cloud Cover Problem:** It was designed to address the tropical cloud-cover problem, as its SAR sensors could penetrate clouds and operate at night, while its optical sensors provided clearer and more intuitive imagery.
 - When clouds obstructed the optical view, the satellite could use **Artificial Intelligence** to generate optical-like images from SAR data, making the information easier for non-experts to interpret.
- **Synchronization:** Drishti used a proprietary technology stack to synchronise its optical and SAR sensors, enabling instant data fusion without manually aligning datasets captured from different angles.
- **Utility:** The satellite was intended to support border surveillance, defence, disaster response, agriculture, infrastructure planning and insurance assessment, particularly during floods, cyclones and landslides.
- **Significance:** The mission reinforced the growth of India’s private space ecosystem alongside companies such as **Agnikul Cosmos** , known for 3D-printed rocket engines, and **Skyroot** Aerospace, which develops privately built rockets.

Read more: [Mission Drishti: World’s 1st OptoSAR Satellite](#)

DRDO Tests Pinaka Long Range Guided Rocket



Source: PIB

Recently, the **Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO)** successfully tested the **Pinaka Long Range Guided Rocket** at the Integrated Test Range in Chandipur, Odisha, validating its minimum strike range of 60 km with high precision.

- **About:** The Pinaka LRGR is a **n indigenous long-range guided rocket** designed to **strike enemy positions, artillery sites, bunkers and logistics hubs deep inside hostile territory** from a stand-off distance.
- **Range:** The rocket had earlier been tested at **its maximum range of 120 km**, while the latest trial established its ability to accurately engage targets across the entire 60–120 km range.
- **Test Significance:** Hitting a target at the minimum range required the rocket to **shed substantial energy and perform steep in-flight manoeuvres**, confirming that the system has no major dead zone within its operational range.
- **Launcher Versatility:** The rocket was fired from an **in-service Pinaka launcher**, demonstrating that the same launcher can deploy multiple Pinaka variants with different ranges without requiring a separate weapon system.
- **Development:** The rocket was designed by **Pune-based Armament Research and Development Establishment** in association with the **High Energy Materials Research Laboratory** , with support from the **Defence Research and Development Laboratory and Research Centre Imarat** .
- **System Features:** A Pinaka launcher can fire a salvo of **12 rockets in about 44 seconds, while a battery of six launchers** can fire 72 rockets and rapidly saturate an area of approximately one square kilometre.
- **Operational Utility:** The truck-mounted system has **high mobility and follows the “shoot and scoot” tactic**, allowing it to deliver concentrated battlefield firepower and quickly relocate to avoid retaliatory strikes.
- **Strategic Importance:** The successful trial strengthens India’s indigenous long-range artillery capability, builds on the Pinaka system’s operational use **since the 1999 Kargil War** and supports the development of reportedly **planned 300-km and 450-km variants** .

Read More: [Pinaka Long Range Guided Rocket](#)